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REDACTION

Behind global capitalism's promise of free mobility lies a profoundly unequal geography of immobility, where the circulation of capital is accompanied by the restriction and stratification of human lives. Migration is often described as a movement of labor, but it is more accurately a global system for the redistribution of life itself. In each situation, migrants are turned into either parts of the labour market or subjects of control, separated from the social and community lives they belong to. However, these methods do not truly show what migration really means in daily life. Migration is not just the movement of workers between countries; it also involves changing how we connect with others, care for each other, and maintain social roles worldwide. It alters family dynamics, shifts emotional and household responsibilities, and creates international ties of support and duty. The world economy is therefore upheld not just by making and trading goods, but also by the ongoing flow of labor that supports life itself. For instance, migrant workers in Spain, Italy, or Gulf Nations often leave their own children behind to take care of children or elderly people in richer families. This creates a situation where care is both given and taken away in different areas of life, leading to what can be called a "double presence and absence": workers are actually in the host nation while still being socially and emotionally connected elsewhere.

Traditional migration ideas—like neoclassical economics, push-pull models, or human capital theory—do not consider these aspects. They depend on a male-centered and production-focused view of work that emphasizes paid jobs while making caregiving work unnoticed. The home is seen as a neutral space instead of a location for political and economic activity, and migration is separated from the power dynamics that shape global capitalism. Feminist Political Economy (FPE) addresses these shortcomings by showing that capitalism is not just about production but also about social reproduction. With the increasing involvement of women in migration, the development of global care networks, and the shift of caregiving jobs from the Global South to the Global North, migration becomes a key way through which global capitalism is maintained.

Our dissertation therefore examines how Feminist Political Economy reconceptualizes migration as a system of global social reproduction and how this perspective reveals the gendered, racialized, and postcolonial structures sustaining global capitalism. It claims that migration is not just an outside effect of global capitalism but one of its essential structures, simultaneously supporting capitalist growth, gender disparities, racial injustices, and postcolonial power dynamics.

I. Reconceptualizing Migration: Feminist Political Economy, Power and Social Reproduction

Neoclassical economics, push-pull models, and human capital theory view migration as an indivaulistic decision aimed at maximizing income and driven by job market incentives. Migration becomes a technical response to global inequalities instead of being seen as a process rooted in social and political contexts.

These theories have three major limitations. First, they focus on productivity, emphasizing paid work while overlooking unpaid and caregiving tasks. Second, they use an individualistic approach, simplifying migration to personal decisions and ignoring systemic limitations. Third, they take a state-centered viewpoint, disconnecting migration from histories of colonialism, capitalism, and racial inequality.

Feminist research has strongly opposed these ideas. Cynthia Enloe points out that the global economy relies on making women's work invisible, especially in household, military, and international contexts. Feminist approaches created by Ackerly, Stern, and True stress the importance of basing knowledge on lived experiences and daily actions to comprehend global power dynamics. Security-focused perspectives further underscore how migration is framed as a danger. Researchers like Didier Bigo and Nicholas De Genova argue that "illegality" is not a natural state but a construct shaped by border policies, surveillance practices, and administrative classifications. A clear example is Moroccan seasonal farm workers in southern Spain, who provide vital labor for the European food industry while facing legal and social instability, highlighting the dual realities of structural dependency and political marginalization.

Feminist Global Political Economy (FPGE) reinterprets capitalism as a framework reliant on both production and social reproduction. It highlights how capitalism is interconnected with patriarchy, racism, and colonial authority. Silvia Federici explains that the history of capitalism included the harsh transformation of reproductive work, which involved controlling women's bodies and normalizing unpaid household tasks (Federici, 2004) Reproductive work is therefore not separate from capitalism but essential for it to operate.

In this context, migration becomes part of a worldwide split of reproductive labor. Migrant women are not just laborers filling job gaps; they play a crucial role in maintaining the global care system. A clear example is seen with Filipina domestic workers employed in Hong Kong, Italy, and the Gulf States. These women support families in richer nations while depending on remittances and international family networks to care for their own families. Migration thus rearranges care on a global scale, creating uneven but mutually dependent systems of social reproduction.

Social Reproduction Theory, developed by Lise Vogel and Tithi Bhattacharya, focuses on the processes necessary for the maintenance and reproduction of labor power, including domestic labor, care work, education, and emotional support. Nancy Fraser argues that capitalism contains an internal contradiction: it depends on social reproduction while simultaneously undermining its material and institutional conditions. (Fraser, 2016). Neoliberal restructuring, austerity policies, and welfare retrenchment intensify this contradiction, producing a global crisis of care. This crisis is particularly visible in Southern Europe. In Spain and Italy, demographic aging combined with reduced public care provision has generated a structural demand for migrant domestic workers. Migrant women from Latin America, Eastern Europe, and the Philippines increasingly fill this gap, effectively privatizing social reproduction within households. Migration thus operates as a systemic response to the crisis of care generated by capitalist accumulation.

II. The Feminization of Migration: Global Care Chains and Transnational Reproduction

A. Feminization of Migration in Neoliberal Capitalism and Global Care Chains

Since the late 1900s, movement of people has become more female-driven. Women are now moving on their own, mainly to take part in domestic work, caregiving, and jobs in the service industry. This change is strongly connected to economic reforms: the cutting back of welfare systems, the sale of care services to private companies, more women joining the workforce, and an aging population in developed countries. In Spain, for instance, migrant women make up a significant number of domestic workers, frequently hired informally in private homes where work protections are limited or missing.

Arlie Hochschild describes global care chains as world-spanning networks where emotional and caregiving work is moved across borders. (Hochschild, 2000)

These chains are shaped by overlapping inequalities involving gender, race, social class, nationality, and migration status. They link homes around the world in uneven but connected relationships. A common care chain can be seen for instance,in the Philippines: a woman leaves to work as a caregiver in places like Hong Kong or Dubai, while her kids are looked after by her mother, who might rely on money sent home from abroad. Care is thus shared among various generations and places. Postcolonial thinkers like Aníbal Quijano and María Lugones suggest that these setups continue colonial ways of extracting resources and establishing hierarchies, placing the Global South as a source of affordable caregiving work for the Global North.

B. The Intimate as a Geopolitical Space

The increase of women in migration and worldwide care networks makes it hard to see the line between personal and political matters. What looks like personal choices about family and jobs is actually part of bigger systems of global capitalism that change how social care is done internationally. Care jobs are not fairly shared based on gender, class, race, and citizenship. Migrant workers from developing countries support care services in wealthier nations while depending on cross-border care systems in their home countries. This leads to broken yet linked types of family life and emotional duties across different countries. From a Feminist Political Economy view, the personal realm is not apart from global power dynamics but is an important area where these dynamics are created and maintained. Migration shows how social care is a mainly international and unequal process.

III. Migration, Security Governance, and the Reproduction of Global Hierarchies

A. Neoliberal Border Regimes and Migration Governance

Modern capitalism shows a conflict between the unrestricted flow of capital and the limited movement of people. Therefore, migration management does not seek to completely stop migration but instead aims to control and manage labor movement based on the demands of neoliberal economies.

Researchers like Didier Bigo suggest that migration has been increasingly viewed through a security lens, which means that migrants are seen as dangers to national safety, social unity, or public order. This security-focused viewpoint justifies the militarization of borders, detention facilities, surveillance methods, and strict visa policies. Nicholas De Genova also indicates that migrant “illegality” is created by government policies. Legal uncertainty serves as a way to control labor since undocumented or temporary migrant workers are often found in exploitative industries like agriculture, construction, and domestic labor. The European Union’s border externalization strategies showcase this pattern. Treaties with Morocco, Libya, and Turkey change these nations into buffer areas responsible for managing migration before migrants arrive in Europe. Meanwhile, European economies stay fundamentally reliant on migrant workers.

A specific example is the farming industry in southern Spain, where Moroccan seasonal workers support intensive agricultural production while dealing with short-term contracts, limited movement, and unstable legal situations.

B. Coloniality and Racialized Labor Hierarchies

Migration systems also reflect colonial and racial rankings found within worldwide capitalism. Postcolonial thinkers like Frantz Fanon, Aníbal Quijano, and Achille Mbembe show that colonial types of control continue in today's labor markets and migration rules. Migrant workers from the Global South often find themselves in low-paying and racially defined jobs, especially in home and care work. These rankings are influenced not just by class but also by race, gender, nationality, and immigration status. The *kafala* system in the Gulf States is a clear example of this. Migrant domestic workers from the Philippines, Ethiopia, or Bangladesh are legally bound to their employers, creating strong ties of dependency and risk. Workers commonly face limited freedom of movement, long working hours, and inadequate legal rights.

Intersectional theory, especially the work of Kimberlé Crenshaw, helps clarify how various forms of oppression overlap in migration systems. Thus, migrant women face exploitation not just as workers, but also through racialized and gender-based power structures.

C. Contesting Global Hierarchies through Migrant Organizing

Even with existing inequalities, migrants find ways to resist and organize politically. James C. Scott's idea of everyday resistance shows how people deal with, oppose, or avoid control in their daily lives. On a group level, domestic workers' groups and migrant organizations are increasingly striving for labor rights and legal acknowledgment. In Spain and Hong Kong, migrant domestic workers have set up protests, unions, and campaigns seeking better working conditions and social benefits. The International Domestic Workers Federation also played an important part in the acceptance of International Labour Organization Convention 189, which acknowledges domestic work as a type of labor that needs legal security. These efforts contest the hidden nature of reproductive work and advocate for different political views focused on care, dignity, and fairness in society.

CONCLUSION :

Migration shows and aids in the worldwide reshaping of social reproduction within the setting of capitalist globalization. In a nutshell, this essay has stated that migration is not just a simple movement of workers motivated by economic reasons. Through a Feminist Political Economy viewpoint, it is seen instead as a system of global social reproduction rooted in neoliberal capitalism, gender roles, and postcolonial authority structures. Feminist criticisms of traditional migration theories reveal that main ideas hide reproductive labor and do not consider the gendered and racial aspects of global movement. Migration is thus more than just labor movement across borders; it is also a means by which care, household work, and emotional labor are spread around the world.
The feminization of migration and global care networks show how developed capitalist countries depend on migrant labor from the Global South to handle the care crises caused by neoliberal changes and cuts to welfare. Social reproduction then becomes international while still being very unequal. Migration control and border policies further strengthen global hierarchies through security measures, legal differences, and externalizing borders, creating migrant insecurity while ensuring a steady need for their labor. In the end, migration highlights the connection between the personal and the geopolitical: daily acts of care and separation are strongly influenced by the global setup of capitalism. Migration is therefore not outside the global gender economy but one of its key foundations.

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